Simple dietary tips for diarrhoea patients!

- Include plenty of fluids like fruit and vegetable juices, soups, thin dals and coconut water
- Small and light meals is preferred than three big meals to replenish the lost nutrients
- Boiling, steaming, baking, pressure cooking should be encouraged
- Include banana and apple as they are rich in potassium
- Restrict consumption of milk and milk products
- Try to avoid raw vegetables
- Avoid fried foods

8.1.2 CONSTIPATION

Constipation is defined as difficulty or infrequent passage of stools. Patients with constipation have hard stools, physical discomfort of straining and incomplete evacuation. It usually occurs in children, adolescents and adults taking low fibre diets, patients who are confined to bed and in elderly people.

There are three types of constipation. These are:

a. Atonic constipation

In atonic constipation, there is loss of muscle tone. This results in weak peristalsis. The causes of atonic constipation are lack of fluids, low fibre diet, irregular defecation habit, poor personal hygiene, sedentary lifestyle and excessive use of laxatives

b. Spastic constipation

Constipation due to excessive tonicity of the colon wall is known as spastic constipation. The increase in muscle tone in colon causes spasms in intestine which leads to constipation.

The spasm is usually accompanied by pain, flatulence and abdominal cramps.

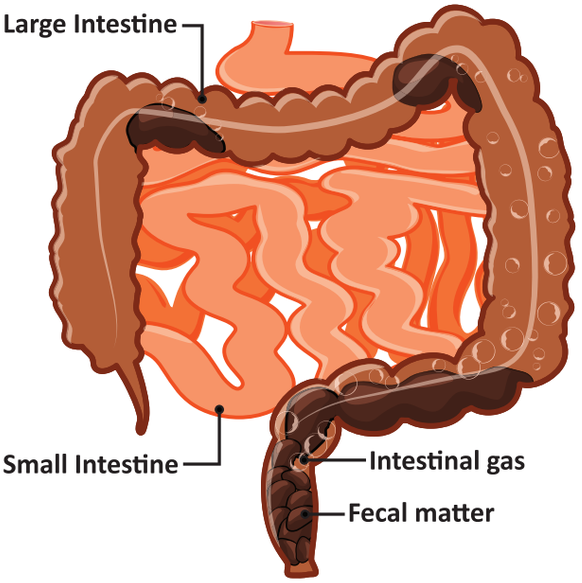
c. Obstructive constipation

Constipation occurs due to any obstruction in the colon. The obstruction is caused by cancer or inflammation which narrows the lumen resulting in constipation

Causes of constipation

The common causes of constipation are:

- Lack of fibre in diet
- Insufficient intake of fluids
- Poor elimination habits
- Ignoring the urge to defecate
- Overuse of laxatives
- Side effects of medications
- Lack of exercise
- Pregnancy
- Hypothyroidism
- Other causes like celiac disease, duodenal ulcer, gastric cancer, anal fissures and hemorrhoids





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